

CHAPTER 36 — The Old Job

Sunday morning, Voss put the girl in the yellow coat back together.

Not literally.

He knew her name now.

He had said it aloud once, days earlier, after finding it in a file he had spent years pretending was only a reference number.

He had not written it anywhere new.

There was no reason to.

Vale still remembered her as the girl in the yellow coat.

That was enough.

Four boxes covered the folding table in the rented office.

Seven years of contractor work.

Invoices.

Route sheets.

Vehicle logs.

Old call records.

Copies of instructions nobody had expected to matter once the invoice was paid.

Reyes had kept too much.

They had mocked him for it.

Receipts. Fuel slips. handwritten timings. Duplicate route sheets. Notes on the backs of envelopes because apparently throwing paper away had offended him personally.

Now he was dead, and half the truth was surviving because he had been incapable of clearing a desk.

Vale lifted one of the files.

"First job."

Voss nodded.

The girl had already been in temporary safeguarding by then.

Her mother was in residential treatment.

Contact remained active.

The case record expected review and, if things continued in the right direction, movement towards reunification.

Nothing about that part was hidden.

Nothing needed to be.

Westmere commissioned Voss's team to move the girl from one temporary placement to another.

Real local-authority placement team.

Real contact number.

Real authority.

Registered temporary placement at the other end.

Voss had checked it at the time.

The sort of checking he used to think was thorough.

Vale read the note at the bottom of the transport sheet.

Child distressed during transport. Requested mother repeatedly.

She sat down.

"I remember that."

Voss looked at her.

"The job?"

"The voice."

He waited.

Vale looked somewhere beyond the room.

"She was angry."

"Children often were."

"No. Properly angry."

A memory started to form.

Not a face.

Rain on glass.

A motorway service station.

A child folded into the corner of the back seat wearing a bright yellow coat that looked better suited to September than whatever freezing month they had been driving through.

Vale frowned.

"Reyes gave her his coat."

Voss looked up.

"What?"

"She was cold."

"You sure?"

"Yes."

He tried to find it.

Nothing.

Then—

Reyes opening the rear door.

The girl refusing to admit she was cold.

Reyes telling her he did not care whether she admitted it because her teeth were doing the paperwork for her.

The coat.

His coat.

Far too big.

Sleeves swallowing her hands.

Voss sat very still.

"I remember the services."

Vale looked at him.

That part returned suddenly.

A motorway café with sticky tables.

Reyes standing at the counter buying hot chocolate.

Voss asking whether he intended to put it through expenses.

Reyes looking offended.

"Of course."

"You can't expense hot chocolate."

"Humanitarian intervention."

Vale smiled.

A small one.

"He said he'd invoice the council."

"He never did."

"No."

Reyes had paid for it himself.

Then complained about the price for thirty miles.

The girl had held the cup in both hands inside the ends of his sleeves.

Voss could see that now.

Strange.

He still could not clearly see her face.

But he could see the cup.

The oversized coat.

Steam against the glass.

Reyes pretending not to notice when she stopped asking for her mother for long enough to drink.

Vale touched the old transport sheet.

"That one was real."

"Yes."

"We checked."

"Yes."

"Her mother was still in the process."

"Yes."

"Contact still running."

"Yes."

"And we were taking her between temporary placements."

"Yes."

They had been helping.

Not perfectly.

Not heroically.

They were contractors.

They arrived, moved a frightened child from one authorised place to another and left.

But the authority was real.

The safeguarding pathway was real.

The possibility of the girl returning to her mother was real.

Voss put the file on the left side of the table.

Neither of them labelled it.

They did not need to.

Then Vale reached for the second file.

* * *

Eleven weeks later, they moved the same girl again.

This time Westmere had not commissioned them.

Meridian had.

Voss remembered Meridian.

That was becoming part of the problem.

Names that had once meant invoice numbers and call sheets were beginning to mean people.

Meridian's instruction described the job as:

PROTECTED PLACEMENT RECOVERY

At the time, the words had done what official words were designed to do.

They made urgency feel lawful.

Maternal contact suspended.

Placement authority transferred.

Recovery permitted.

Transport permitted.

Relocation permitted.

Destination restricted.

Authority attached.

Voss looked at the order.

The same sort of document North Vale had contradicted the day before.

Not this exact one.

Same architecture.

Vale checked the times.

“Job opened Sunday.”

“Yes.”

“Collection Monday.”

“Yes.”

“Authority Monday.”

“Yes.”

She stopped.

“The destination is already here.”

Voss looked.

Sunday.

A private residential address.

The house with the white gate.

The house where Vale later remembered a woman crying when the girl arrived.

Voss rubbed his thumb over the edge of the paper.

“Could have been provisional.”

Vale glanced at him.

“I know.”

“Planned transfers can have destinations before final authority.”

“I know.”

A week ago she would have accused him of defending the job. Now she understood what he was doing. Separating what felt wrong from what proved anything. The provisional version read: ACTIVATION PENDING AUTHORITY Vehicle identified. Receiving window agreed. Destination already entered. Household code already present. Vale stared at it. “So they weren’t waiting to find somewhere for her.”

“No.”

“The place was waiting for her.”

“Yes.”

Different statement. Much harder to explain away. She laid the two files side by side. First journey. Westmere. Real authority. Temporary placement. Mother still in the case. Eleven weeks.

Then Meridian. A private household already selected. Maternal contact suspended. Authority arriving after the destination. Same contractors. Same child. Voss leaned against the table. The first time they had been part of safeguarding. The second time their work had become part of the crime. And at the time the difference had looked like paperwork.

* * *

The retired dispatcher remembered Meridian immediately. He did not remember the child. Voss was relieved. That was not what they were calling about. “Meridian liked verbal acknowledgement,” the man said.

“What kind?”

“Instructions. They wanted someone to call back.”

“And say?”

“Something like ‘authority understood.’ Been years.”

Vale looked at Voss. “Did you think that was strange?” she asked.

“Clients were strange.”

“That isn’t an answer.”

"It's the one I've got."

Fair.

Voss asked about planned destinations.

The dispatcher explained what they already suspected.

Yes, a client could reserve a receiving site before final authority arrived.

Yes, vehicles could be held.

Yes, time windows could be planned.

None of that proved a crime.

Then Voss asked the question that mattered.

"When the authority arrived, what did we do?"

"Attached it and released the job."

"Independent check?"

"If the client was approved, why would we?"

Voss looked at Vale.

"Meridian was approved?"

"Of course."

"By who?"

The dispatcher laughed.

"You."

Silence.

"Me?"

"You or Reyes. One of you lot. It was on the list."

Voss found the onboarding file while the man was still talking.

Fourteen months before the yellow-coat job.

Meridian Placement Services.

Approved client.

Reference support:

AC019

Vale saw it over his shoulder.

“Mac.”

“Yes.”

Voss stared at his own old approval notation.

He remembered none of it.

That did not make the handwriting someone else's.

Mac had introduced Meridian into their contractor infrastructure.

Voss's side had accepted it.

After that, Meridian did not arrive as a stranger.

It arrived as a trusted client.

The dispatcher was still on the line.

Vale asked:

“So if Meridian sent an authority document, you assumed someone had already checked Meridian itself?”

“Yes.”

“Who?”

“You lot.”

Voss closed his eyes for half a second.

There it was.

Trust travelling in a circle.

The dispatcher trusted Voss because Meridian was approved.

Voss had approved Meridian because Mac vouched for it and the references looked sound.

Future staff trusted the approval because the approval existed.

Nobody had to invent trust twice.

They only had to get inside once.

Voss thanked the dispatcher and ended the call.

Vale looked at him.

"You approved them."

"Yes."

"Because Mac introduced them."

"Yes."

"You checked references?"

"I would have."

"You don't remember."

"No."

They opened the pack.

One commercial reference was real.

A real logistics company.

Real trading history.

Nothing unusual.

Another route disappeared into the legal-verification structure they now knew had been controlled.

The third came from an ordinary Westmere placement manager.

No sign in the material they had that the manager belonged to the shadow group.

Vale read the reference.

It confirmed something narrow.

Meridian had handled protected transfers.

Probably true.

Someone had taken one ordinary person saying one true thing and used it to support something much larger.

Vale sat back.

"You could build a criminal network out of innocent confirmations."

Voss looked at the real commercial reference.

The Westmere manager.

His own approval.

Mac's introduction.

"Yes."

"That's horrible."

"Yes."

She considered the papers.

"And clever."

"Yes."

"Still horrible."

"Yes."

Vale gave him a look.

"You could occasionally vary your answers."

"No."

That almost made her smile.

Almost.

* * *

At noon, Voss found his own debrief.

Five lines.

He recognised the formatting before he recognised the job.

His template.

His language.

The sort of report designed to close a file without inviting anyone to feel anything about it.

Collection completed without incident.

Child resistant at initial contact.

Authority presented to temporary carer.

No police attendance required.

Recipient handover completed 19:46.

Vale read it twice.

Then tapped the second line.

"Resistant."

Voss said nothing.

"What does that mean?"

"I don't remember."

"You wrote it."

"I wrote hundreds."

"Try."

He looked at her.

He hated the request.

She knew it.

Neither moved. Then Voss looked down at the five lines. Resistant. He let the word sit there until memory stopped being optional. A front room. Wallpaper. A narrow hallway. Someone's television playing in another room. The temporary carer was a woman in her fifties. He remembered that first. Then stairs. The girl behind her. Not screaming. Not fighting. Standing behind the woman. Refusing to come forward. Voss's stomach tightened. "She didn't want to leave." Vale said nothing. The memory

kept coming. The carer asked to see the order. Voss gave it to her. She read the first page. Then the second. Then returned to the first.

Vale had been near the door. Reyes was outside. Engine running. The carer said something about the mother. Voss could almost hear it. "She challenged us."

Vale went still. "What did she say?"

"She said there was contact on Wednesday."

Vale looked at the legitimate case file. "Maternal contact."

"Yes."

"What else?"

Voss pressed his fingers against his forehead. The carer's voice returned in pieces. Treatment completed. Review approaching. Things had been improving. This was not what she had been told would happen. "She said the mother had finished treatment."

Vale sat down. "That's in the real case."

"I know."

"And the review?"

"Next month. Something like that."

Voss looked at the disputed order.

The carer had known enough to question it.

She had done exactly what a responsible person was supposed to do.

She asked for proof.

Then she verified it.

“I gave her the number.”

Vale looked at him.

“What number?”

“The one on the order.”

Neither spoke.

The answer was already obvious.

The carer called it.

Voss remembered waiting.

Remembered being annoyed at the delay.

Remembered thinking the woman was making a difficult job more difficult.

Then she came back.

Her face had changed.

Paler.

Not convinced.

Defeated by confirmation.

Voss could hear her.

“They confirmed it.”

He shut his eyes.

Years later they had given the process a name. Controlled verification. Back then it had simply felt like an obstacle successfully cleared. The

woman questioned the order. The order told her how to check the order. The person at the other end confirmed the order. After that, Voss treated the matter as resolved. Vale said quietly: "She did everything right."

"Yes."

"And we still took her."

"Yes."

He looked back at his debrief. Child resistant at initial contact. Two words. That was what he had turned the scene into. Not: Child frightened. Not: Carer disputed removal. Not: Mother apparently nearing reunification. Not: Verification route supplied by disputed authority. Resistant.

The child had become the problem in the report. Vale looked at the line. "What happened after the call?"

"We proceeded."

"And the girl?"

Voss did not answer. Vale waited. He searched again. Yellow. The coat. Different from the first journey. This time she had it on. The same thin coat. Or one like it. He remembered her standing near the door. Smaller than he had remembered. Children became dimensions in adult memory. Weight. Height. Distance to vehicle. How hard to move. He hated that thought. "What did she say?"

Voss stared at the report. Then memory opened fully.

"She asked whether her mum knew."

Vale looked down.

The room seemed to contract around them.

"What did you say?"

Voss knew.

He had known before she asked.

"I said it was all arranged."

Vale lifted her eyes.

"Was it?"

"No."

Clean.

No as far as I knew.

No the document said.

No we had confirmation.

No.

Voss had told a frightened child that her mother knew what was happening because an official-looking piece of paper had made him feel entitled to certainty.

Vale looked back at the report.

Collection completed without incident.

She gave a short, humourless breath.

"No incident."

Voss said nothing.

* * *

He nearly left that part out of the message to Zoe.

Vale stopped him.

"She needs the process."

"She does not need the child's question."

"She needs to know what we did after the verification."

"That is different."

"No, it isn't."

Voss looked at her.

Vale leaned against the table.

"If we only send the paperwork, we make ourselves paperwork."

He understood.

Did not like it.

Sent the supported sequence.

Temporary carer challenged the second move.

Maternal contact still expected.

Review approaching.

Carer used verification number printed on disputed order.

Order was confirmed.

Contractor proceeded.

Then he added one final line.

I REMEMBER HER ASKING WHETHER HER MOTHER KNEW. I TOLD
HER IT WAS ARRANGED. I DID NOT KNOW THAT.

He stared at it.

Vale did not soften it.

Neither did he.

Send.

* * *

Elias pulled into a lay-by before showing Zoe the message. She read it once. Then again. The second time she stopped at the last sentence. I told her it was arranged. I did not know that. Zoe looked at Elias. "Why would he say that?"

Elias knew what she meant. "Because he thought somebody else had checked."

"But he hadn't."

"No."

"The carer was telling him it didn't make sense."

"Yes."

"And the paper told him it did."

"Yes."

Zoe looked back at the message. For once, she did not reach for the notebook. "He believed the paper."

"Yes."

"More than her."

Elias glanced at the message. "In that moment."

Zoe hated the qualification.

Then realised why he had made it. "Fine."

She stared through the windscreen. Lorries passed on the dual carriageway. Normal. Heavy. Indifferent. "Useful doesn't mean good," she said.

"No."

"Helping us now doesn't fix that."

"No."

"Knowing he was wrong now doesn't fix what he told her."

"No."

She looked at Elias. "You're agreeing a lot."

"You're right a lot."

"That sounds dangerous."

"It is."

She almost smiled. Then the message pulled her back. A child asked whether her mother knew. An adult told her yes. That was all. No code

needed.

* * *

The second job had paid nearly three times the first. Vale found that after lunch. She read the invoice total. Then checked again. "Why?"

Voss took the page. The labels looked respectable. RESTRICTED RECOVERY PREMIUM Confidentiality. Out-of-hours requirement. Destination shielding. Urgency. None of those things were inherently criminal. Real safeguarding work could require all four. Then Vale found another line. COMPLETION DISCRETION FEE "What is that supposed to mean?"

Voss opened the billing note. The explanation made both of them quiet. Payable where recovery completed without external escalation. Vale read it aloud. "No police."

"Yes."

"No outside authority getting involved."

"Potentially."

"No delay."

"Yes."

"Quiet."

Voss said nothing.

Vale looked at him.

"Did we know?"

"Know what?"

"That quiet paid better."

He looked at the old invoice.

"Not enough."

"That wasn't my question."

No.

It was not.

Voss remembered restricted jobs.

Better rates.

More urgency.

More instruction.

Fewer questions.

At the time, they had told themselves the same thing every contractor told themselves.

Protected placements required discretion.

A child fleeing an abusive parent needed secrecy.

A witness needed secrecy.

A family at risk needed secrecy.

Confidentiality could protect people.

That was true.

Which was exactly why the false version worked.

"We knew they paid more for quiet," Voss said.

Vale nodded.

"We told ourselves quiet protected the child."

"Yes."

"And we never asked who else it protected."

"No."

Neither called that an excuse.

Neither called it a confession.

It simply sat between them.

Money had not told them the job was criminal.

But money had made not looking outside the supplied chain easier.

That belonged to them.

* * *

At two fifteen, the house with the white gate stopped being an address.

Voss found the preparation record from a third-party property company.

It began forty-eight hours before the disputed authority.

Not cleaning.

Preparation.

A bedroom made ready.

School-registration paperwork started.

Clothing sizes requested.

Vale read the last line again.

"Sizes."

"Yes."

"They knew which child."

"They knew enough."

"Before the order."

"Yes."

She looked at the dates.

Before collection.

Before the authority that supposedly made the transfer lawful.

A room already waiting.

School paperwork already beginning.

Someone had asked what size clothes the girl wore.

Vale sat very still.

She thought of the first journey.

Yellow coat too thin.

Reyes's coat hanging off her hands.

Hot chocolate.

Eleven weeks later, somewhere else, somebody had been preparing clothes for her before the authority to send her there existed.

"The house was waiting."

"Yes."

Voss said it quietly.

No argument now.

Vale took a pen.

On the paper she wrote:

THE JOB WAS DELIVERY TO A PRESELECTED HOUSEHOLD.

Voss read it.

"That is interpretation."

She looked at him.

"Of course it is."

"We can prove the household was prepared before the authority."

"And what do you call taking the child there?"

"Movement under disputed authority."

Vale stared at him.

"You've become unbearable."

"So have you."

She looked at the sentence.

Then drew a line through it.

Underneath she wrote:

RECEIVING HOUSEHOLD PREPARED FOR THIS CHILD BEFORE
DISPUTED AUTHORITY DATE.

Voss nodded.

She capped the pen.

"I liked mine better."

"I know."

* * *

They stopped there.

That mattered. Vale could have searched the girl. School. Medical records. Current address. Whether she still lived with the receiving household. Whether she had ever returned to her mother. Whether her mother was still alive. She wanted to. The desire surprised her with its force. Not professional. Personal. She wanted one decent ending somewhere in the file. A reunion. An apology. A photograph. Anything that would reduce what sat on the table. Her hand rested on the

keyboard. Voss watched. "Don't." "I know." "You don't need her current life to prove the job." "I know." Vale stared at the screen. "She'd be grown now."

"Yes."

"Almost."

"Yes."

"What if she found her mother?"

Voss did not answer.

Vale closed the laptop.

Harder than she expected.

The girl had already spent enough of her life being turned into something useful to adults.

A case.

A transport subject.

A recipient match.

Evidence did not give Voss and Vale the right to do it again.

* * *

Mac learned Voss had reopened the old placement at three thirty-eight.

Someone inside the property-service company reported the enquiry.

No child name requested.

No current address.

Only preparation timing.

Historic paperwork.

Mac found that more worrying.

Curiosity searched for people.

Method searched for structure.

He called restricted legal.

"Voss is reopening old placements."

"Yes."

"Stop him."

Silence. Mac heard himself. The word now carried too much history.

Stop. Move. Recover. Contain. Every verb had begun producing witnesses. "No."

His solicitor waited. "Do not stop him."

"What do you want?"

"Which file?"

The reference came back. Mac recognised the route family. Not his recipient household. Not his sponsorship. That mattered. "Was AC019 connected to the child?"

"No."

Mac exhaled. Then the solicitor continued.

"To Meridian."

He stopped. "How?"

"Onboarding."

Of course. Years earlier. An introduction. A reference. A favour. Something that had felt nowhere near the act itself. Mac sat down. One person recommended a company. Someone else accepted it. Another person sent an instruction. A contractor trusted the approval. A household waited. A child moved. No single small act looked like the road when you stood on it. Only afterwards did the road become visible. "Do nothing," Mac said.

He ended the call. For once, doing nothing frightened him more than action. He did it anyway.

* * *

At four o'clock, Voss and Vale reduced the old job to what they could actually support.

No ten-point theory.

No accusation about who had designed the whole route.

No claim that Mac had sponsored this child.

He had not.

No claim that the Westmere reference in Meridian's onboarding knew what it was helping authenticate.

They did not know.

Voss typed only the facts that mattered.

The girl had been on a legitimate temporary safeguarding pathway with maternal contact and reunification still active.

Their first transport had been lawful.

Eleven weeks later, Meridian commissioned a protected recovery.

The private receiving household was selected and prepared before the disputed authority.

The temporary carer challenged the movement.

She used the verification route supplied on the order.

The route confirmed it.

Voss's team proceeded.

The second job carried a premium and a completion fee tied to avoiding external escalation.

Meridian had entered their approved contractor system through onboarding supported by AC019.

Then Vale added one sentence.

WE DID NOT VERIFY OUTSIDE THE SUPPLIED CHAIN.

Voss read it.

"That is the important part."

"Yes."

No excuse.

No:

We were deceived.

No:

We were innocent.

No:

We only followed instructions.

Just what they had failed to do.

Voss sent it.

* * *

Zoe read the message at five ten.

She ignored most of the first paragraph because she already understood it.

Her eyes stopped at the end.

WE DID NOT VERIFY OUTSIDE THE SUPPLIED CHAIN.

She read it again.

Elias was driving.

She turned the phone towards him.

"That's better than saying they were tricked."

"Yes."

"Because they were tricked."

"Probably."

"But that doesn't make them innocent."

"No."

Zoe looked back at the sentence. "They knew quiet paid more."

"Yes."

"They saw the carer object."

"Yes."

"They had a verification route."

"Yes."

"And they used it."

"Yes."

"Still wrong route."

"Yes."

She frowned. "Stop saying yes."

Elias glanced at her. "You are asking questions with one-word answers."

"That sounds like blame."

"It is diagnosis."

She almost laughed. Then: "Useful doesn't mean good."

"No."

"Helping now doesn't make them heroes."

"No."

She waited.

Elias added:

"It makes them useful witnesses."

Zoe considered that.

Did not write it down.

The notebook had enough labels.

Voss and Vale were people.

People could have failed badly and still tell the truth later.

They could help without being forgiven.

They could be responsible without being Cain.

The world remained inconvenient.

* * *

They stopped for dinner beside a canal.

Zoe ordered steak pie.

Elias ordered vegetables with something pretending to be interesting underneath them.

She stared at his plate.

“What?”

“That is punishment food.”

“It’s dinner.”

“You chose it.”

“Yes.”

“Voluntarily.”

“Yes.”

She shook her head.

“Disturbing.”

For ten minutes they discussed nothing more serious than whether peas counted as an ingredient or an act of aggression.

Then Zoe went quiet.

Elias noticed.

Waited.

She pushed a piece of pastry through gravy.

“Voss believed the order.”

"Probably."

"The carer believed the phone call."

"Yes."

"Vale believed it."

"Seems so."

"Reyes?"

"Likely."

She looked at him.

"So who knew?"

Elias did not answer immediately.

That made it a better question.

"In that specific job?"

"Yes."

"Someone knew the household before the authority."

"Yes."

"Someone knew enough about the girl to prepare for her."

"Yes."

"Someone supplied the order."

"Yes."

"Someone controlled the verification."

"Yes."

"And Meridian knew where the contractors were taking her."

"Yes."

Zoe put her fork down. "But none of that tells us whether one person

knew all of it.”

“No.”

“Could be several.”

“Yes.”

She looked annoyed. “At least make me work for the yes.”

“No.”

That got her. She laughed once. Then the question returned. Not who moved the child. They knew that. Not who received her. They had that too. The missing piece was higher. Who could make a legitimate case bend in several places at once? Who knew there was a child moving towards reunification? Who knew the household waiting on the other side? Who arranged the authority between them?

Who knew which contractor would accept it?

Who knew which verification route would stop questions?

Maybe nobody saw all of it.

Maybe that was the point.

But somebody had to see enough.

Zoe did not make a list.

She finished the pie.

* * *

That night, Vale sat alone in the rented office for another twenty minutes after Voss had gone downstairs.

The two files remained on the table.

First journey.

Second journey.

She opened the first.

The transport note was still there.

Requested mother repeatedly.

Vale could hear her again.

A small angry voice from the back seat.

Reyes telling her the hot chocolate was too hot.

The girl saying she knew that.

Reyes asking why she was trying to drink it immediately, then.

“Because I want to.”

His coat almost swallowing her whole.

Vale looked at the second file.

Child resistant at initial contact.

Eleven weeks.

That was all.

Eleven weeks between one report that recorded a child asking for her mother and another that turned her refusal to leave into resistance.

Vale placed the files together.

She did not search the name.

She already knew it.

She did not search where the girl was now.

She closed the box.

That was all she was entitled to do tonight.

* * *

Zoe wrote one sentence before sleeping.

Not a system diagram.

Not a classification.

Just:

They helped her once. Then the same trust helped take her away.

She looked at it.

That was the part she kept coming back to.

The vans were not evil.

The roads were not evil.

Temporary placements were not evil.

Confidentiality was not evil.

Paperwork was not evil.

Even Voss and Vale were not simple enough to fit neatly inside the word.

The shadow route had survived because almost everything around the lie could be real.

Real contractors.

Real carers.

Real safeguarding.

Real concern.

Real confidentiality.

Real people trying to do their jobs.

Then one false authority entered the chain.

And the whole structure carried it forward.

Zoe added nothing else.

Across the room, Elias was checking the lock.

"Tomorrow?" she asked.

"North Vale may contact Westmere."

She looked up.

“Directly?”

“Priya thinks so.”

Zoe thought about the temporary carer.

She had questioned Voss.

Then called the number Voss gave her.

The supplied chain had answered itself.

Tomorrow a legitimate authority might do something Voss and Vale had failed to do years earlier.

Ask another legitimate organisation directly.

Outside the chain.

Zoe closed the notebook. “Good.” Elias switched off the lamp. For once, the next move did not belong to them.